state. Rather expectedly, the Chogyal, China, and Pakistan deemed the whole affair a sham. [33]

Relations between India and China remained frosty for fourteen years after the 1962 border war. Full diplomatic relations at the ambassadorial level were only resumed in 1976. But the same year as ambassadors returned to Beijing and New Delhi, China entered into an agreement to supply nuclear weapon assistance to Pakistan, a culmination of significantly closer relations between the two countries over the previous fifteen years. Between 1967 and 1979, China also provided training and arms to Naga, Mizo, and Manipuri rebels. Relations only began to improve with External Affairs Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee's visit to China in February 1979, by which time China appears to have stemmed rebel support. [34]

After 1980, China's new leader Deng Xiaoping raised the possibility of a territorial swap or 'package deal' with India, during interviews and bilateral meetings with Indian officials. This was a loose offer to recognize the McMahon Line in exchange for India recognizing China's control of Aksai Chin, similar to Zhou Enlai's suggestion of 1960. In December 1981, Sino–Indian border talks resumed, and in 1983, China agreed to Indian demands for a sector-by-sector discussion. These revolved around resolving the boundary through minor territorial concessions by China in the western sector in exchange for a visit by Prime Minister Indira Gandhi in her capacity as chairwoman of the Non-Aligned Movement (a 'package deal-plus' option). While Beijing seemed open to the prospect of ceding some of the area between its 1956 and 1960 claim lines in Ladakh, the package deal-plus was rejected by New Delhi for domestic political reasons. Instead, the Indian government considered the possibility of exploring such a deal after the 1985 General Elections. [35] It is possible that Chinese proposals, like in years past, would not have been seen through to a full resolution.

In October 1984, Indira Gandhi was assassinated. The next year, with a new prime minister in power and changing international circumstances, China walked back its package deal-plus offer. In late 1985, Chinese negotiators pressed their claims south of the McMahon Line, to the surprise of the Indian side, a position that was reiterated a year later. [36] In 1986,